Week 29

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 8 · LESSON 1

Love

BIG IDEA

Your students now know a lot, but knowledge shared without love misses the point; as Paul says, without love it's all for nothing. This week is about sharing faith with love and humility, listening well and building relationships, not winning arguments or counting conversions.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Paul says in 1 Corinthians that even if we can do amazing things, without love it is all for nothing. That's why we keep coming back to love.
2. With so much knowledge gained, it's easy to get caught up in being right, earning spiritual notches or winning arguments instead of sharing with love.
3. Train students to share faith in love and humility: sit back, listen, take a genuine interest in the other person, and be like Jesus.
4. Intro activity: students recall a time they felt loved, so they understand how others should feel when we show love.
5. Go a bit off script and role-play: show conversations with love and without it. Some students lean toward arguing, others toward just agreeing.
6. Remind them they'll mess it up, and that's okay: it's a skill that grows. Focus on relationships, not conversions; our love is how some will see Jesus.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. In conversations about faith, am I more focused on being right or on the person in front of me?
2. Which of my students lean toward arguing, and which toward just agreeing to keep the peace?
3. Who outside church is getting to know Jesus through how I treat them?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. Think of a time you felt really loved. What did the other person do?
2. What's the difference between winning an argument and actually loving the person you're talking with?
3. In the role-play, what made the loving conversation feel different from the other one?
4. What are some ways to show love to someone that you hadn't thought of before?
5. Who is one person you could build a real friendship with this month, and what would that look like?

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WEEK 29 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Talking about love again

0:06 You might be thinking that we're talking about love again, and your students might look at it and think, "We're talking about love again." Well, we're going to keep talking about love, because love is so important. Paul said it in 1 Corinthians, right? If we have all this stuff, if we're this amazing person and we can do all these amazing things, but we don't have love, then it's all for nothing.

0:31 So we want to make sure that we talk about love. At this point, you and your students have walked through an incredible amount of information. In fact, they're so much more intelligent and, hopefully, confident in their conviction for what we as Christians believe. It's exciting to think, when I look back at this book, about all the things they've studied and that you have gone through. It's really, really exciting to think back to even just where we started from.

The temptation to be right

1:06 But it's also really easy, after you've been through all of this, to have so much knowledge crammed into your head. You might have — and I hope you have — students who are really excited to share what has now been crammed into their heads, and hopefully in ways that their hearts have been changing and have been incredibly impacted by what you've studied over the last several months. And yet, instead of sharing that with love, sometimes we get caught up in trying to be right. Sometimes we get caught up in trying to get notches in our spiritual belt. Sometimes we get caught up in trying just to win the argument and to beat down on somebody else's beliefs or somebody else's faith.

Love and humility

1:53 That's not how we want to do it. So we wanted to make sure that we took time out to communicate the idea of communicating your faith to others in love and in humility. That can be really difficult to do. It can be difficult to train someone to sit back and actually take the time to listen, to take the time to be interested in what somebody else says, to take the time to really be just like Jesus.

2:24 So that's really what this lesson is all about. We want your students — just like we put inside the introduction activity — to think about what it looks like and what it feels like at a time when they actually experienced love. We want them to go back into that moment, so that they understand what they felt like, and so that they understand how others ought to feel when they express love of some kind to another person.

Going off script with role-playing

2:50 So for this week, I'm going to take you a little bit off script — and maybe for next week as well. I want you to work on something. I want you to work on role-playing. It's not necessarily what's inside here, but after walking with you through this process, I sat back and thought that I really feel like you need to do some good quality role-playing now. That might be between two students, that might be between you and another student, or another adult leader and a student. But the idea here is that it's a teachable moment.

3:27 You want to show students what it looks like to engage in a conversation with another person in love. But you also want to show students what it looks like to engage another person in conversation without love. They need to see both. Even if you have two students, and one of them is displaying something that's good, maybe one of them is displaying something that's not so good. Don't ridicule them, but use this as a teaching moment so that they can see it, because some students are just bent toward arguing.

3:57 I've had students over the years who, no matter what you do and no matter how you say that they're trying to be loving, they just want to argue and they just want to win. And other students don't want to argue at all — they just want to be agreeable. Based on different students' personalities, they need to see a couple of different things. So involve as many students as you can, get them role-playing a little bit, and use those things as teachable moments, so your students can get a feel for what that looks like and feels like before they ever go out into any kind of conversation.

They're going to mess up

4:28 But they are going to go out into conversation. I hope they go out and have conversations — but remind them that they're going to mess it up, and that's okay. They're going to come back and say, "Oh, I should have said this," and "Oh, I came off wrong," and "Oh, I said this wrong," or "I didn't think of this," or "I forgot that." It's okay. The fact that they remember those things afterward will continue to build their confidence, and they'll continue to get better and better and better.

4:58 Just like anything else, this is a skill that has to be developed. But encourage them to continue to use it. Encourage them, and find ways as a group to get out together, so that you can do things together and encourage each other and spur one another on. But make sure your students see exactly what love ought to look like, in as real a scenario as you can get.

Small group time

5:19 Okay, so small group. Small group time is going to be interesting, because what you have an opportunity to do this time is to talk with students about how they can love in different ways — maybe in ways they've never thought of. Depending on the dynamic of the particular group, they might not be able to think of love in the particular terms that another student can think of, so students need each other to bounce ideas back and forth. That way they can understand how it all will work in their particular situation. How one student perceives loving another

person is going to be far different than maybe another student. So use your small group time as a way to open up that conversation, to really explore all the different ways that students can connect with other people in a way that Jesus would.

Relationships, not conversions

6:10 Okay, so the last thing. We talk about love because love is what builds relationships. Please remember that it is so important to build relationships. Make sure your students understand that this is not about getting conversions — this is about building relationships. Jesus said to his disciples that it's by your love and by the way you treat one another that they'll know that you are my disciples, and that they'll know who I am. The way in which we love other people is how some people are only ever going to see Jesus. Don't focus on the conversions. Focus on the relationships, and focus on the ways in which we can love others.